

PLEASURE -- THE FULL PULSATION OF LIFE

Greetings to all my friends here who are gathered together for the purpose of obtaining nourishment and truth in whatever way they need it at the moment. Tonight's lecture deals with the topic of pleasure, the meaning and significance of pleasure in the scheme of the universe as well as for the individual human entity.

Religion speaks of the ultimate bliss of being. However, this is, most of the time, completely misunderstood. The bliss of being is believed to be a state that is totally different from the human state of ultimate pleasure or from the human potential for it, whether it be realized or not. Therefore bliss seems very remote from the human experience. It appears to be something totally disembodied and obtainable only eons later. This kind of bliss appears so unreal to man and even so far away from what he considers truly desirable, that it remains, at best, a vague theory.

In reality, there is essentially no difference between the ultimate, spiritual state of bliss and the human potential for it. Only the degree of intensity varies, for no human being is capable of the depth of experience which is possible for unstructured highly developed consciousness. But pleasure remains pleasure. Spiritual pleasure is not bodiless, for even unstructured consciousness is not formless. It creates the so-called "subtle bodies," consisting of streaming energy in the purest form. This energy form is without obstruction. It is pleasure itself. The human body represents in its gross matter an obstruction that can be overcome only when the total personality attains harmony with the energy streamings of cosmic origin.

A very liberated human being with little or no blocks and inhibitions, without distortions and negativity, is capable of a high degree of pleasure, for the energy of the subtle bodies penetrates the surface body. We often spoke about the fact, and you know from your own experience, that the longing for pleasure and, at the same time, the fear of it is one of man's most basic inner struggles. Tonight we shall discuss the need for pleasure -- the legitimate need -- and its purpose for the human entity. I will show that this need is not only not in opposition to true spiritual self-realization (as many people falsely believe) but is, in fact, one of its necessary prerequisites. Or to put it differently, he who blocks pleasure must perforce also block the deep connection with his spiritual self. Conversely, only he who is free enough to let go in one respect is free to do so in the other. And these apparently "two" experiences -- spiritual self-realization and the capacity for pleasure -- become one and the same. They are interactive and interdependent.

We shall also talk about the obstructions that barricade you from the deep experience of pleasure supreme. What are these obstructions? What is the hindrance to the realization of that state which will always be the goal of your greatest longing, whether or not you are aware of it? Yet, you, in your own soul, obstruct this longing and are therefore in a state of war within yourself.

I do not wish to dwell too long on the cosmic meaning of pleasure. As I implied before, this always runs into the danger of making it appear as too remote from your present life right now. In reality, this is not so at all, for all cosmic reality is applicable at any state in the now. But it is easy to misread and misapply. Only when a person reaches the point where he can open the inner flow to remove all inner obstructions and blocks so that a high degree of bliss is experienced, will he deeply know that human pleasure is essentially the same as the cosmic state of bliss, that spiritual and physical pleasure are one -- not opposites. Pleasure, in the real sense, is intensely fleshly and intensely spiritual. There is no division between the fleshly and spiritual state of man. This is why there is no need to dwell too much on the philosophical aspects of pleasure in the scheme of creation. The only thing I would like to mention about cosmic reality in this regard is that the ultimate state of liberation, of cosmic being, is total pleasure. The ultimate reality is pleasure. It is not, as religion seems to imply in its misunderstood interpretations, that bliss is a reward for having been "good." It is the natural state of a unified being in harmony with himself and the universe.

When we speak of pleasure, we must also be clear about what is meant by it. I do not mean pleasurable pastimes of the mind; I do not mean shallow substitutes and escapes. I mean a state of physical and spiritual bliss that is experienced in every particle of one's body and soul, of the outer and inner being -- with all sensations and faculties alive, awake, and feeling. This state is very much here and now. Yet this state is also the ultimate spiritual reality of every entity. It is your birthright, my friends. Your longing for it is the most real and healthy movement within yourself. It is only your confusions and dualistic splits that create misconceptions and fears and shames that are so superfluous.

Let us now come to the meaning of pleasure for the human being on all levels of his existence. The pleasure we speak about here is, as I said, a total experience, not a divided experience. It is not a physical experience with the spiritual self left out. Nor is it a spiritual state that does not include the physical state. It means that your entire being vibrates and pulsates undividedly in harmony with yourself, the universe, and hence with another human being. There is no division in you, no no-current, no doubt about the rightfulness of your bliss. There are no if's and but's because your bliss interferes with the world around you. You feel no guilt or hesitation. On the contrary, you will deeply feel that the greater your ecstasy, your pleasure, your joy, the more you contribute to the world. When you reach this inner awareness -- not a theoretical, but an experiential awareness -- you will create the following conditions within yourself. You will make the total experience of pleasure a spiritual and practical goal. You will act unceasingly on behalf of this goal. You will remove all inner obstructions and patiently explore your own unconscious in order to bring the obstructions to light. You will devote time and effort to this venture. You will feel increasingly that personal fulfillment and pleasure further spiritual growth and realization, and vice versa. The capacity to love intimately and completely with your body, your soul, and your spirit will be the goal that simultaneously furthers your self-purification, for one cannot exist without the other. I will say more about this aspect later.

Let us first discuss what full pleasure means on all levels of the human personality. As regards the physical level, physical health and well-being is totally regulated by and dependent on the state of pleasure a human body is capable of allowing. Since the streamings of pleasure are, at the same time, the forces of life, health, self-renewal and regeneration; health and longevity are results of the capacity for pleasure. Conversely, to the degree you deny yourself pleasure -- due to shames, fears,

misconceptions, negativity, impurity, etc. -- to that degree you cut off your body from the wellspring of the universal flow.

You have often heard me say that each human entity is in microcosm a universe within himself or herself, representing the macroscopic universe. The same laws apply, the same conditions apply. Now, if your inner universe is in harmony with itself, the universal flow of spiritual healing power, of life, of health, and of pleasure that permeates the entire creation also permeates you. You become part of the universe, and the universe is part of you. You transcend the structural limitations even while you are still within your body. The universal, unlimited abundance of ever self-renewing life will become a part of you -- relatively, as you are still in the body. This happens absolutely only when the body is transcended. But this must never be confused with the idea that the feelings you experience in an unblocked body and soul condition also cease to exist. This is error. On the contrary, the body feelings come from the subtle bodies and can manifest just because the body blocks are removed. When bodily existence is transcended, those identical feelings will manifest ever so much stronger because they are even less blocked by the gross matter of physical existence. Hence, it is important to understand that feelings you register in your body -- feelings of pleasure and bliss -- will not cease to exist in an existence beyond the earth life. They will only be intensified. You will be better capable of sustaining the feelings of pleasure supreme, of ecstasy, of bliss, of love, of what is called sexuality on this earth sphere, that is, total fusion with another being. (I am talking about those entities who have put false fears and obstructions behind them; otherwise their spiritual existence will not be different from their earthly one.)

Any kind of physical illness or deterioration, therefore also physical death, as it were, is a manifestation of division, conflict, and denial of pleasure. It is therefore correct to say that spiritual unfoldment must bring an increase of pleasure and not, as many authoritarian religions want to have it, denial and sacrifice of pleasure. This concept of martyrdom is total misunderstanding of spiritual truth. But this truth, as I say it here, can be understood only when pleasure is no longer negative and therefore no longer at the expense of another human being, when it no longer carries destructive currents. Anyone can confirm the truth that the degree of deeply experienced pleasure determines energy and well-being. This is not something you have to take at face value. You can experience it yourself.

Now let us go to a deeper level as regards the importance of pleasure. From a psychological point of view, the importance of pleasure is at least as great as from a physical point of view. How can you shoulder mature self-responsibility? How can you accept the difficulties of the temporary reality which surrounds you and which is, in effect, the expression of your state, where you are now within yourself? How can you be asked to deal and cope with the frustrations that come your way? Of course, they come your way, in the last analysis, due to your own inner limitations, but nevertheless you also have to accept your own limitations, and that is not easy. How can you really want to give up the various ways in which you violate and impair your integrity, in which you want to secretly cheat life, in which you want others to carry the burden of responsibility for your mistakes? How can you truly commit yourself to integrity, truth, deepest honesty, and a positive approach to yourself and life? How can you wish to abandon negative pleasure? the pseudosatisfactions of your pretenses, your role-playing, your defenses? How can you begin to wholly and consciously commit yourself to the reality of living, not for the sake of appearances, but for the sake of what is, when you are not aware of the fact that the deepest bliss is awaiting you just

as a result of abandoning these pseudosatisfactions and pleasures, these poor substitutes? As long as you are convinced that these substitutes are all there is to life as far as pleasure is concerned, and that decency of living implies sacrifice for its own sake, you cannot even believe in pleasure. This difficulty is intensified by the fact that you cannot bear pleasure to the degree that you cling to all these false ways of life. You become capable of admitting pleasure only to the degree you give up the false, negative pleasure.

You must therefore find a way to break through the vicious circle in which you are caught. The less you can truly want to give up all these subtle falsities and subterfuges, the destructive defenses, the less you can accept pleasure. Therefore you cannot believe in it. Therefore you cannot want to give up that which obstructs you from experiencing it. Therefore there exists no real will or commitment for either pleasure or the giving up of destructive, life-inhibiting patterns of feelings, attitudes, and actions.

Accepting reality and mature self-responsibility seem an insurmountable hardship if the realization of pleasure is not a simultaneous by-product. So we can say with absolute accuracy, to the degree you cease being an irresponsible child who wants to make others pay for your actions or the lack of them (projection), to the degree you want to secretly, neurotically cheat life, to the degree you impair your integrity in all these ways I discussed in a recent question-and-answer session, to that degree you cannot experience pleasure. Your innermost being does not make it possible. The energy is engaged in these negative inner activities. But it is equally true that to the degree that you assume full self-responsibility, to the degree you respect and love yourself because you inwardly no longer cheat in the subtlest of ways, to that degree you become more and more capable of the realization of pleasure.

It is also true to state that the more you can look forward to a full and blissful existence, the less hard will it seem to give up these destructive patterns on the deepest level imaginable, to stand on your own feet, to accept necessary frustrations. This equation of the acceptance of full autonomy with the capacity for pleasure is extremely important to comprehend. For the one is not possible without the other. If being a deeply self-responsible and decent person, in the innermost sense of the word, seems to imply that pleasure must be renounced, then pleasure cannot really be wanted or, if it is, then only in an unhealthy way as a reward to the "good child" from an authority figure one depends on.

You will want selfhood, autonomy, in the truest sense of the word, however hard it may first seem to attain it, if you will know that your own fear of pleasure will disappear proportionately to your self-purification. To the degree you assume the apparent hardship, at first of adulthood with all its ramifications, something in you will ease up and feel less and less threatened. Instead, you will become open to pleasure in its deepest and fullest meaning.

All of you can meditate about this equation, about the connection between emotional maturity with all its meanings, on the one hand, and the realization of personal pleasure, on the other. This is really very logical, my friends. You know that you can only truly love when you are self-responsible, not when you cling to someone else, when you are dependent on someone else. Such dependency may have the superficial appearance of love, but you have already experienced in your work on this path that nothing could be further from the truth. In fact, dependency stems from fear and creates greater fear, therefore inevitably resentment and hate. You try very hard to conceal these feelings

because it is threatening to experience hate for the person one needs and depends on. Love is possible only when you are free, when you are a self unto yourself without depending on another. And pleasure is possible only when you love. As I said before, sexual pleasure without love is very incomplete and must always wind up in a dead end street. There will always be something missing. It is an expression of inner division of the spirit, the soul, and the body. Total unification of pleasure exists when you love and when you are a sexual being. When you love and are a sexual being, you are also a spiritual being. This means that you have emotional and mental integrity. Therefore pleasure and spirituality, pleasure and decency, pleasure and emotional maturity, pleasure and physical health are all intricately and intimately connected.

Now let us consider the obstructions to pleasure. I would like to say that some of you who are here for the first time and are unfamiliar with the depths we are working with here may not know at all what I am talking about when I mention the fear of pleasure. Offhand, you all want pleasure and long for it. Partially you really strive for it. You believe you want it, but you ignore the fact that you also do not want it, that, in fact, you desperately fear it. My friends here, who are already somewhat advanced on this path and have explored their own hitherto unconscious being to a sufficiently profound degree, have found indeed that they are often terrified of pleasure -- perhaps even more than of negative feelings within themselves or coming to them from others. I have elsewhere pointed out the connection between the fear of negative feelings of yourself, of others, and the fear of pleasure within you. For only as you fear pleasure do you then inadvertently, and logically, want the opposite -- the unpleasure. Thus you fear the result of your negative desire, for deep inside of you, you know what you want will be so. And the less conscious you are of what you want, the more you must fear the result. Hence, fear of death always connotes an unconscious death wish.

Fear of pleasure must be made conscious in order to battle it. Otherwise your battle against your own fear of pleasure will consciously manifest in an excessive striving for pleasure, in an anxiety about not being able to realize it, in a pessimism or even hopelessness about it, which makes you fluctuate between two damaging extremes: from resignation to compulsive, blind, and consequently inappropriate overactivity. This obstructs the attainment of pleasure to a considerable degree. Conversely, pleasure is made possible when the state of mind and emotions is quietly confident, calmly expectant and receptive, patient and unanxious, unhurried and unworried. One of the first obstructions to look for is the dichotomy, arising from an unconscious rejection of the desired result, whether pleasure or anything else, for that matter -- anxious striving, hopeless resignation. Hence, unawareness of being afraid of it must be transformed into acute and direct awareness of it. This is not easy, but it is certainly possible on this path. Anyone who seriously desires it can obtain this awareness of his unconscious.

I said in the last lecture that your negative creations, your negative pleasure must be made conscious in order to be overcome. By the same token, it is necessary to be in touch with your denial of pleasure. Here I might safely say that no human being is completely free of it. The degree varies, but it is only a question of degree. But even those of you here who are relatively free from fear of pleasure, I ask you, do not overlook those areas within yourself where you shrink away from pleasure as though it were danger. Meditate and commit yourself to wanting to be aware of it. Then the next step can be executed, the exploration of the validity or invalidity of this fear so that you can finally really want to give up this fear and obstruction to an ever increasing degree.

Only when you are acutely conscious of how you fear and deny your pleasure will you stop making others responsible for your deprivation which makes you keenly suffer. A deep inner burden will dissolve, the burden of being puzzled and hopeless of not attaining what you deeply yearn for. This burden is subtle and unpronounced. Once you can ascertain in full consciousness, "I am afraid of pleasure," hopelessness will disappear. You will feel the two forces within yourself: one pulling you toward pleasure, the other away from it. You will feel these two forces on all levels of your being -- in your mind, in your feelings. When the battle goes on unbeknownst to your conscious mind, it is extremely painful. When you know of its existence, you can begin to settle the conflict. Once the struggle is conscious, it can be met. It can never be met when it is unconscious. This is why the making conscious of any condition is about the most important undertaking for any human being. You can never free yourself of the vague anxiety and the feelings of hopelessness and inadequacy, which are the result of your not knowing that you deny what you want -- which you wish, on the one hand, and fear on the other. As it is impossible to overcome your destructiveness, your negativity, without knowing that you want to be negative, so it is impossible to settle this struggle and fight within you unless you know and feel and experience that this fight goes on within you.

Just as with the negativity I discussed in the last lecture, you will also have to find out the further consequences of your denial of pleasure, and why you do so. The first thing I would like to say about why you are afraid of pleasure is this. Again the connection with the last lecture must be made. Your holding on to the negativity, your not wanting to give up negative and destructive patterns of behavior, of feelings, makes the real pleasure not only undeserving in your own unconscious estimation, but also actually frightening. It is too frightening to be open to it, for your negativity creates a state of soul and body that is essentially incompatible with pleasure. It creates tension, separateness, contraction. It comes from an excessive ego orientation. It is therefore totally alien to a state of pleasure. Negative pleasure is always, in some way, more geared to gratifying ego goals than fulfilling the real and legitimate needs of the entity for bathing in the light of pleasure supreme. It harbors the three attitudes that are at the roots of all destructiveness and deviation -- yes -- pride, self-will, and fear. I said this many years ago. Where there is pride, where there is self-will, where there is fear, there must be a state of contraction.

Contraction cannot be fully given up, ever, no matter what approaches of therapy are used and no matter how good they may be, as far as they can go, if pride, self-will, and fear are not abandoned. In pride, self-will, and fear, the ego structuring becomes more tight and rigid. Self-will says, "me, me, me" -- the little me, the little self, the self that puts its stake only into the outer, conscious ego personality and that completely disregards, ignores and rejects the greater consciousness, the cosmic consciousness, the universal consciousness, of which you are an expression. Unless the total person is unified with this greater consciousness that transcends the ego, holding on to the ego becomes imperative. The ego would not be so emphasized if the false belief would not exist that the self is annihilated the moment the ego is not the sole ruler of the human life. Hence, when you identify exclusively with the ego, you cannot identify with the greater consciousness nor with the feelings in your body, for they go hand in hand. For direct experience of spontaneous feelings in your body are as much an expression of the universal truth of being as the guidance inspiration and knowledge that spontaneously flow into you when you identify with your being that extends beyond the ego consciousness. If you identify with the ego, you create a tightness in the ego structure that says in effect, "It is my ego world that counts. This is all there is to me, and therefore I cannot give it up. Otherwise, I cease to exist." With this attitude, pleasure

becomes impossible, for total, real pleasure depends on the ability of the ego to let go of itself and to let itself be carried and lived by a greater power within the body and soul.

Pride says, "I am better than you." This means separateness, it means one-upmanship, it means everything that is opposed to a state of love. By the same token, pride may also manifest as, "I am worse than others, I am worthless, I have no value. But I must hide this fact, so I must pretend that I am more." Of course, these thoughts are not articulate, but they may not be altogether unconscious. This distorted pride (as opposed to healthy dignity) is always comparing and measuring the self with others and is thus perpetually in illusion. For no true evaluation can ever come from this. It is a hopeless and endless chase for an illusory goal that leaves the personality not only exhausted, but also more and more frustrated. The chasm between the self and others widens forever more, love becomes less possible, and hence pleasure further removed. It does not matter whether you actually think you are more than others or only pretend in order to hide your feelings of worthlessness. It is all the same. This cannot produce love, and how can true pleasure ever be realized in a loveless state? Love is not a command that is supposed to deprive you. It is the most selfish of all attitudes, for it brings the greatest of all pleasures, bodily as well as mental and emotional pleasure. It simply feels good in yourself. It opens you up, you flow and pulsate in a state of peace, security, vibrancy, excitement, stimulation, and utter confidence. Your innermost being and your outer limbs feel sweet and fulfilled when you love. But when you are in an ego state of pride, you must be tense, anxious, contracted. You cannot pretend while being in a relaxed state. And pride always leads to and requires pretense of some sort. A relaxed, struggleless, and unpretending state is the absolute prerequisite to pleasure.

Fear, needless to say, is a total contraction. It cannot trust anyone, or the self, or the universe. Therefore the self that is in fear cannot let go of itself. Pleasure is unrealizable when the personality is bound to the ego, bound in self-will, pride, and fear, bound in the negative creations, bound in the struggle within itself that denies its own negativity and hence does not know it exists. Hence, it does not know of the nature of its own suffering. The self is bound in the struggle of wanting and fearing the same end. Unawareness of this struggle leads to frustration and discontent, as well as to rendering others responsible for the lack, which in turn elicits resentments, bitterness, anger, defiance. The resulting confusion is torment for the soul.

As I said, the realization of pleasure you all deeply long for comes from letting go of all of these destructive attitudes. Let me recapitulate. A totally relaxed inner state is needed for pleasure, but relaxation is not to be confused with passive apathy, paralysis, or inertia. True relaxation is a constant, harmonious movement. It is the movement of the universe. Any human entity who is sufficiently free to be in this unified state of pleasure will feel the cosmic pulsating rhythm and will be in harmony with it. This pleasurable rhythm of the universe is in each microscopic universe. It means being very finely attuned to the cosmic rhythm within. It means following the soul movements -- not of distortions -- the movements that are the reflections of the greater Cosmos. In order to be thus attuned, an inner calmness must prevail. All the agitation of the mind must settle down. The turbulence must cease. Then another kind of movement within you will make itself known that is neither active nor passive in the outer sense, but it combines an inner activity and movement of the most pleasurable rhythm with an inner, calm receptivity and apparent motionlessness, which is not contradictory to the former, but an intrinsic part of it. What appears to be a contradiction on the ego level becomes a unification on a different wavelength. In that state, there can be no division or struggle against the self. There can be no pushing or tense striving. In

that state, there is no harassment from time, for there is timelessness, even now, while you are in the body.

Of course, we take it for granted that this state cannot be realized at all times. But it can be realized again and again, leaving you each time a stronger, more unified, more complete person with your ego fully intact, more integrated with the greater self. It is by now self-evident that development, growth, evolution of the individual must bring you to the more frequent realization of this state, most significantly and intensely experienced in a love relationship. But in different ways, you will experience this state in all you do, in the way you live, move, and have your being in the universal consciousness, in all your undertakings, and in your very being. Wherever you are at any given moment, you can transcend this one instant no matter how unpleasurable it is. If you go sufficiently deeply into yourself to fully explore the you in this moment, in this situation, if you do not escape from it, this very moment of unpleasure must turn into its ultimate nature: pleasure supreme. It is not easy to do this when you are so separate in your perception of yourself, even after you have experienced some of these truths and states I mentioned. In such a state of disconnectedness, it requires your probing and groping to find the right measure of self-discipline, self-facing, of summoning your good will to see the truth and change the destructiveness, on the one hand, and patient letting go and waiting, trusting expectancy, on the other. You have to find the right answers and attitudes, of struggling and not struggling, both in the right way and the right measure. Memory of a former similar state in your mind will be of little help. The truth must be recaptured each time anew. Memory will only help you to know that the truth can be attained and is not an illusion. No, it is not easy to transcend your now and get into your inner cosmic rhythm within yourself. But the more often you attempt it, the more often it will become possible until this eventually becomes your normal state and disconnectedness the exception. The difficult times will increasingly serve the purpose to bringing you nearer toward your inner center of being, where pleasure supreme reigns. These difficult moments will then be the catalysts they are meant to be in order to ready your whole person for the state of pleasure that is unconflicted within you. As you accept the pain that you have created through your own misconceptions and destructiveness, and do not cringe or run from it but explore it, as you hold still instead of fighting against it with your subterfuges, negativities, your games and roles and pretenses, your projections and your escapes, as you truly look at yourself, the attainment of pleasure and the state of being in pleasure will ultimately and increasingly unfold itself for you. You will become an integral part of it. That must be the aim. So, pleasure is, at one and the same time, the ultimate spiritual and human goal. It is also the curative agent without which you cannot heal.

I think you begin more and more to realize that such a path is not to be dreaded as a difficulty or a chore. Every particle about it is the most joyful thing in itself not only because it brings ultimately liberation, but even while you are struggling and each time you win over a struggle, it brings you bliss in varying degrees. The degree depends on your ability to overcome resistance to do so -- exactly to that degree, my friends.

Be in the state of bliss that is your birthright, that is your ultimate destiny for all of you. Realize the truth that there is nothing to fear. Be blessed.

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